Though the Games are 11 years away, India's enormous population, rapid economic growth and lack of previous hosting experience make it a strong contender. "Hosting the Olympics is the dream of 140 crore Indians, it is their aspiration," Prime Minister Narendra Modi had declared in his August 2024 Independence Day speech. The buzz in bureaucratic circles in the PM's home state had begun as early as 2021, the intent also made an appearance in the BJP manifesto for the 2022 assembly election.

WHAT IT WILL TAKE

For a country to host the Olympics, the IOC mandates conducive geopolitical, socio-economic, human development and environmental factors; political will, a masterplan of the vision and its alignment with long-term development; sports, accommodation and transport facilities; sports events experience, and safety and security, among other things.

India has in the past five decades hosted four multi-country non-cricket international sporting events—the Asian Games in 1982 and the Commonwealth Games in 2010, both in Delhi, the 2017 U-17 FIFA World Cup in six cities, and the 2022 FIFA U-17 Women's World Cup across three cities.

Summer Olympics typically feature 28-35 sports with 184 countries participating and nearly 203 National Olympic Committees. Paris 2024 had 10,714 athletes across 32 disciplines, while the Los Angeles 2026 edition will have 35 core sports, with some 10,500 athletes and their support staff. The biggest games India has hosted so far, the CWG in 2010, saw 71 Commonwealth teams and 4,352 athletes across 21 sports.

Though the IOC does not specify the number of stadiums a country must have to host Olympics, France had 35 sporting venues and Tokyo 41. However, Gujarat, or perhaps any city in India for that matter, lacks infrastructure of the required quality and scale. Also, the IOC has in the past few years been asking countries to cut down costs, and make use of existing venues or temporary ones and consider the 'sustainability and legacy' impact of the Olympics. India will therefore have to demonstrate that it has the resources to develop high-end sports infrastructure without compromising on its social sector spend. Government sources estimate it will cost Rs 35,000-64,000 crore to host the Olympics. But this seems conservative given that the Paris Olympics, which had one of the lowest budgets, cost $8.9 billion (Rs 76,626 crore). Many events were staged in venues built for the French Open and the 2016 European Football Championship. "At the outset," says Manisha Malhotra, president of the Inspire Institute of Sport, "India's budget would be thrice that of, say, a Los Angeles Olympics (2026)."

The battery of bureaucrats putting India's case before the IOC intends to argue that the additional infrastructure will boost the economy which, in turn, will benefit society for years to come. "Hospitality, tourism, transportation, retail et al will benefit from the influx of visitors for the multiple small and big sporting events that will be hosted in the countdown to the Olympics and afterwards," says a senior office-bearer and member of the Indian Olympic Association (IOA).

WHAT MAY WORK IN INDIA'S FAVOUR IS ITS **ENORMOUS POPULATION, RAPID ECONOMIC GROWTH** AND THE FACT THAT IT HAS NOT HOSTED THE OLYMPICS BEFORE



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IS INDIA READY FOR THE OLYMPICS?

To host the Games, a country must demonstrate political will, funding and sports, accommodation and transport infrastrucure. How we fare...

No. of athletes

Paris 2024: 10,714 athletes across 32 sports

Tokyo 2020: 11,000 athletes across 33 sports

India: CWG 2010, the biggest games India has hosted so far, saw 4,352 athletes across 21 sports

GUJARAT GETS SET

Whether or not India gets the nod, Gujarat started work on its Olympian ambition three years ago. The state's sports and culture ministry along with the urban development department have been reimagining Ahmedabad and Gandhinagar as modern international sporting hubs and priming them to host multiple sporting events in the run-up to 2036. In March, India submitted an interest in hosting Commonwealth Games 2030 in Ahmedabad. The state will also be hosting the Commonwealth Weightlifting Championship this year and the Asian Weightlifting Championship in 2026.